🥪 The Coaching Sandwich

🍽️ The Plate – Ethics & Way of Being

Every great sandwich needs a solid plate under it — something that holds the whole experience with integrity. In coaching, that plate is **Core Competency 1 - Demonstrates Ethical Practice** and **2 - Embodies a Coaching Mindset**. This includes your ethical foundation, professionalism, presence, mindset, and the way you *show up* as a coach.The plate ensures everything is supported, grounded, and delivered with clarity and care (and doesn't end up in your lap!)

🍞 The Top Slice of Bread – Establishing the Focus

The bread on top sets the structure for everything that follows. Without it, everything falls apart in your hands. Asking permission to record, creating a safe space, and clarifying what success looks like for the client sets the flavor profile for the whole sandwich. This is where we decide what we're about to bite into.

This layer is aligned with **Core Competency: 3 - Establishes & Maintains Agreements.**

Choose 1 question from each category:

🔹 **Question 1: Session Focus -** ***What are we working on today?***

- What would you like to focus on today?
- What feels most important for us to spend time on today?
- If we only had time to focus on one thing today, what would matter most?
- What feels most pressing for you to focus on today?
- What's taking up the most space in your head or heart right now?
- Of everything you could bring today, what feels most useful to explore?

🔹 **Question 2: Define Success -** ***What needs to happen for this to be a win?***

- What would success look like for you by the end of today's session?
- By the end of this conversation, what would make it feel valuable for you?
- When we get to the end, how will you know this session was successful?
- If this session goes really well, what shifts for you? (*If they've expressed a desire to shift something.)*
- What would be different at the end of our time together? (*If they've expressed a desire to change.)*
- At the end of this session, what specifically needs to happen for you to call it a win?
- If we fast-forward to the end, what are you hoping you'll be able to walk away with?

  (Keep asking until you have a clear answer.)

🥬 The Lettuce Layer – Where Are They Now? (Current Situation)

Lettuce brings the crispness and texture—just like exploring the client's current situation, feelings, impact, and importance. **Skip this layer and you miss the crunch—the real feel of what the client is experiencing in the moment.** Notice the texture here: emotions, body language, energy shifts. This layer reveals what's really going on beneath the surface.

This layer is aligned with the following **Core Competencies: 3 - Establishes & Maintains Agreements; 4 - Cultivates Trust & Safety; 5 - Maintains Presence;** and **6 - Listens Actively.**

🔹 **Reflect back what they've shared, and then ask:**

🔹 **Question 1: Explore Significance - *Why does this matter to you now?***

Choose 1 question:

- What impact is it having on you right now?
- Why is it important to you right now?
- What makes this worth spending time on today?
- What's at stake for you here?
- How is this affecting you right now?
- What happens if this stays the same? (*If they've expressed a desire for change.)*
- What becomes possible if you gain clarity on this? (*If they've expressed a desire for clarity.)*
- What does this connect to that feels bigger for you?
- What feels meaningful about addressing this now?
- If this were resolved or understood, what would that give you? (*If they've expressed a desire for resolution/understanding.)*
- Why does this matter to you right now more than it might seem on the surface?

🔹 **<u>Notice</u> what's not being said here - emotions, body language, energy shifts - and <u>explore</u> it with the client.** *"I noticed you got choked up* (notice)*, can you tell me more about that?* (exploration)

🍅 The Tomato Layer – Clarify & Confirm the Session Goal

Tomatoes add brightness and clarity—just like helping the client define what's most important for *this* session. This is where you check flavor, balance, and structure: "Are we slicing this thick or thin?" You ensure the goal is achievable for right now.

This layer is aligned with the following **Core Competencies: 3 - Establishes & Maintains Agreements; 4 - Cultivates Trust & Safety; 5 - Maintains Presence;** and **6 - Listens Actively.**

🔹 **Question 1: Clarify and Confirm the Outcome - *What are we working toward now?***

Choose 1 question:

- You said you wanted to get X out of this session—is that still the case?
- After our exploration, what is your ideal outcome for this session?
- If that bigger goal isn't possible today, what smaller step would move you closer?
- Given what we've uncovered, what feels most important to accomplish in today's session?
- What specifically do you want to walk away with now?
- Has your desired outcome shifted since we started talking?
- If we were to make this concrete, what would we be working toward?
- [Reflect previously stated outcome.] What would make this outcome clear and specific for you now?
- Of everything we've discussed, what do you want to prioritize in today's session?
- After everything you've shared, what needs to happen today to feel complete with this conversation today?
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- If we were to name the outcome for today's session in one sentence, what would it be?

🔹 **Reflect back their clarified outcome and have them confirm before moving into the coaching.**

🥩 The Protein – Evoking Awareness by Asking Powerful Questions

This is the heart of the sandwich—the coaching itself. The substance. The reason you ordered it. Here, you challenge stories, explore perspectives, invite silence, and ask the questions that open awareness. This is the nourishment your client came for.

Use this space to **challenge stories, use silence, explore emotions and limiting beliefs.**

This layer is aligned with the following **Core Competencies: 4 - Cultivates Trust & Safety; 5 - Maintains Presence; 6 - Listens Actively;** and **7 - Evokes Awareness.**

Ensure you **incorporate at least 1 question from each category.** The flow is flexible—coach in response to what's emerging.

🔹 **Obstacle / Challenge Questions - *What's in the way?***

- What's really stopping you right now?
- What's the real challenge here?
- What feels hardest about this?
- Where are you getting stuck?
- What are you avoiding?
- What's the part you don't want to admit?
- What are you protecting by staying here?
- What belief might be holding this in place?
- What story are you telling yourself about this situation?
- What feels risky about moving forward?

🔹 **Perspective-Shifting Questions** - ***What's a different perspective?***

- What's another way of looking at this?
- If you zoomed out, what would you see differently?
- What would someone who believes in you say about this?
- If this were happening for you instead of to you, what might be the purpose?
- What assumption are you making here?
- What might you be missing?
- If this were simple, what would you do?
- How would future-you handle this?
- If you removed fear/doubt/guilt/shame/anger/grief/frustration/resentment/disappointment/comaprison/insecurity/perfectionism/pressure/expectation/obligation/worry/overwhelm/regret/judgment of self or others/people-pleasing (whatver is holding the client back) from the equation, what changes?
- If you removed the belief that you're not ready/the belief you might fail/the need to get it right/the story you've been telling yourself from the equation, what shifts?
- What becomes possible if the opposite of your story is true?

🔹 **Learning / Insight Questions - *What are you discovering?***

- What are you learning about yourself right now?
- What does this reveal about what you value?
- What pattern do you notice here?
- What strength of yours is showing up here?
- What part of you is growing through this?
- What truth is emerging for you?
- What are you seeing more clearly now?
- What insight feels important to hold onto?

🧀 The Cheese Layer – Insight/Learning into Action

Cheese ties everything together—it melts into the rest, bringing cohesion and commitment. Insight turns into aligned action. This is where things get flavorful and real.

This layer is aligned with **Core Competency 8 - Facilitates Client Growth.**

Turning Insight into Action involves three steps: **Integrate, Act, Sustain.**

Choose 1 question from each category:

🔹 **Question 1: Integrate the Insight - *What changed, and how does it matter?***

- What feels most important from today's conversation?
- What have you learned about yourself?
- What shifted in your thinking?
- What feels clearer now?
- How does this new awareness change how you see the situation?
- What belief or pattern feels updated?
- What do you want to remember from today?
- How does this align with who you want to be?
- What truth are you leaving with?
- What feels different now compared to the start?
- What insight do you want to anchor before you choose your next step?

🔹 **Question 2: Design the Action - *How will this show up in your behavior (tangibly)?***

- Given this insight, what's your next step?
- What action are you ready to take?
- What feels most aligned to try next?
- What feels possible for you right now?
- What's one meaningful step you could take this week?
- What specific behavior reflects this learning?
- If you were to act on this, what would that look like?
- What's within your control to move forward?
- What experiment could you run?
- What commitment are you willing to make?

🔹 **Question 3: Strengthen Follow-Through -** ***What will support execution and accountability?***

- How committed are you (1–10)? What does a/an # mean to you?
- What might get in the way?
- How will you handle resistance if it shows up?
- What support do you need to follow through?
- Who else needs to be involved?
- What resources would make this easier?
- How will you hold yourself accountable?
- How would you like to support yourself in following through?
- How will you measure progress?
- What will remind you of this commitment?
- What will success look like when you follow through?

🍞 The Bottom Slice of Bread – Closing the Session

The bottom bread holds everything together so the client can “carry” their insights out of the session. This is the reflection, celebration, and integration—the grounding layer so nothing falls apart on the way out the door.

Choose 1 question from each category:

🔹 **Closing Part 1: Summarize the Experience - *Consolidate learning and value.***

- What has been most valuable for you today?
- What stands out as most useful from our conversation?
- What insight feels most significant?
- What are you taking away from this session?
- What shifted for you during our time together?
- What feels clearer now? *(If they were looking for clarity.)*
- What feels most meaningful about what we explored?
- What part of today’s conversation will stay with you?
- What are you walking away understanding differently?
- If you had to sum this session up in a few words, what would you say?

🔹 **Closing Part 2: Anything Else? - *Create space for completion.***

- Is there anything left unsaid that feels important?
- What haven’t we touched on that matters?
- Is there anything lingering before we wrap up?
- What else would feel important to acknowledge?
- Is there anything you need before we close?
- What, if anything, still feels unfinished?
- Is there a question you’re still holding? (or Is there a question you wish I had asked?)
- What would make this feel fully complete for you?
- Is there something you almost said but didn’t?

🔹 **Closing Part 3: Close the Session - *Partner on ending the session with intention.***

- Is this a good place for us to land today?
- Are you satisfied with where we’ve arrived?
- Does this feel complete for now?
- Are you ready to close here?
- Does this feel like a natural stopping point?
- Are you comfortable ending here today?
- Does this feel aligned with what you needed?
- Would you like to continue exploring this next time or close it here?
- Are we at a good pause point?
- How are you feeling about where we’re ending?